feints, but her thrusts are always bold, brash and writ in capital letters. The temple at Digha is a curious amalgam of both: a striking bid to steal the BJP's thunder, to neutralise any edge that Hindutva grants it. The TMC is likely to retain its state-backed secularism, but Mamata seems to be shifting to a more even-handed approach to symbolic appeasement, and dramatically enlarging her political vocabulary to do so.

Any mass mental diversion from headaches like Murshidabad, the Waqf debates or the school recruitment scam, and the Rs 250 crore spent on this pink sandstone architectural hybrid would have been well worth it. Returns are also expected via another Ayodhya/Kashi replay: the shrine is envisioned as the nucleus of a religious tourism hub, with annual footfalls of one million.

Initially planned in 2018, the project has come to fruition at a propitious time for Mamata, with the last lap for the 2026 state election crackling with heat. The temple has been entrusted to ISKCON, but Mamata is front and centre. She composed a devotional song for the *pran pratishtha*, and donated a golden broom worth Rs 5 lakh for the rath yatra. Three ornate chariots await their inaugural roll on June 27; the ambitious plan is to replicate Puri's annual affair.

The BJP shrugs off Mamata's Hindu grandstanding, but its regime in Odisha ordered a probe into how men and material from Puri flowed out. Also, Digha is in Purba Medinipur, heart of Suvendu Adhikari country. Mamata's ex-aide, now arch foe and saffron stormtrooper, he has been vocal against the temple. "A boom in local religious tourism will help corner Suvendu," says a TMC insider. The CPI(M) has criticised the use of public funds for religion, but that's unlikely to halt Mamata's juggernaut. ■



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

Takeaways

- **Mamata delivers a grand response to Hindutva: a new Jagannath temple at Digha**
- **Copies Ayodhya playbook, from live-stream of yajaman act to tourism hub ambitions**

▶ GUJARAT

GANDHI'S GROUND 'ZERO'

Rahul Gandhi's revitalisation programme waters the roots in the districts, but the tree is also barren at the top

By **Jumana Shah**

THE PAST THREE WEEKS HAVE been a frenetic blur for Naushad Solanki. District chief for the Congress in Surendranagar, his political life usually reflects the placidity of this Saurashtra outback. So why has he been meeting and interacting with so many



ANI

REVAMP EXERCISE Rahul Gandhi with Gujarat party chief Shaktisinh Gohil at the District Workers' Conference in Modasa, Gujarat, Apr. 16